Clear instructions and front-loading

Specify participation before the task

Use front-loading when students begin responding or moving before they have heard the participation instructions. Say how to respond before giving the content that will capture attention.

How to do it well

1 Plan the action. Define the response location, participation mode, stopping point and what students should do if finished or stuck.

2 Secure attention. Use the shared signal and wait until students can access the instruction.

3 Front-load participation. State how students will respond before presenting the interesting question, object or task.

4 Check receipt. Ask a student to state the first action or a key restriction, clarifying briefly where needed.

5 Release clearly. Use the agreed cue, display any useful reminder and observe the first actions before moving into individual support.

What this sounds like

“In silence, write one answer on your board and keep it hidden. What are the two response rules? Now the question: which source is more reliable?”

Classroom example. Before displaying a diagnostic question, the teacher states that pupils will choose silently on boards and keep answers hidden. A listening check retrieves those rules. The question is then shown and the class commits privately. The interesting content has not arrived before the participation instructions, reducing unwanted calling out and contaminated responses.

Top tips that make the technique work

Put participation first. “On your board, silently…” comes before the question, not after an answer has been called out.

Keep the instructions numbered. Students can retrieve the first action and the checking point more easily than a long paragraph of directions.

Use an Instruction Sandwich. State the instruction, check that students heard it, then restate the concise version before release where useful.

Display complex directions afterwards. A stable reminder can support action without competing with the original spoken message.

Use a clear release cue. “When I say go” separates listening from movement and prevents the first instruction being lost.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Specify where, how and when students respond.	Asking the question and adding instructions afterwards.
Check listening before students act.	Repeating every direction automatically without finding out what was missed.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

Barton — Front-load the means of participation